



unesco

Mahatma Gandhi Institute of
Education for Peace and
Sustainable Development

Skill 3: Emotional Awareness

Module Objectives

By the end of this skill, you will be able to:

- Define emotional awareness
- Explain the importance of emotional awareness
- Identify afflictive and beneficial mental states
- Identify the nature of your thoughts
- Create space between speech and action to have greater mental balance and be less reactive
- Apply relevant tools to practice calmness.

What is Emotional Awareness? Why is it important?

Emotional Awareness is the ability to be aware of our mental experiences at each moment and differentiate between beneficial and potentially harmful mental states.

When someone asks how you're feeling, no matter what's going on, you might say something like, "I'm fine." But is it possible to always feel fine?

When we don't observe, accept and manage how we feel, it might be overwhelming or we might stay stuck in the high zone or the low zone for a long time. This can impact our personal life and professional life and our relationships with others. This is why Emotional Awareness is an essential skill.

Being Emotionally Aware means we are able to observe our thoughts, feelings, emotions, and sensations with awareness as they arise in the mind.

This ability really helps when we need to differentiate between potentially beneficial and harmful states.

Harmful mental states distort reality and can lead to problems like prejudice or hatred. While, beneficial mental states are attitudes and perspectives that lead us toward happiness and away from suffering.

Emotional Awareness allows us to be less reactive and more resilient. When we are able to make proper assessments of our mental states we can then follow up with wise and conscious responses.

For example, both scientific research and common sense suggest that increasing lack of satisfaction, resentment, and stinginess lead to less happiness and poorer relations. An increase in gratitude, forgiveness, and generosity, on the other hand, lead to greater happiness and better relations with others.

Emotional Awareness doesn't mean ignoring our thoughts or emotions. It's using awareness to:

- Observe our mental states with less attachment
- Investigate whether our thoughts and feelings are permanent or temporary
- and to create more space between our thoughts, emotions and speech or actions so that we can be less reactive.

By doing this, we are able to become aware of the mental states and habits we wish to grow stronger and which mental states we want to weaken or transform.

Harmful and Beneficial Mental States

Like we discussed in the previous section, Emotional Awareness is the ability to be aware of our mental experiences at each moment and differentiate between beneficial and potentially harmful mental states.

Beneficial mental state: Beneficial mental states are the attitudes, emotions and perspectives that lead us to happiness and away from suffering. For example, studies suggest that having more gratitude and forgiveness in our lives lead to more happiness and better relationships with others.

Harmful mental states: Harmful mental states distort reality and lead to suffering for ourselves and others. For example, mental states like anger, resentment, jealousy can lead to bitterness, unhappiness and poorer relationships with others.

Spark to Forest Fire

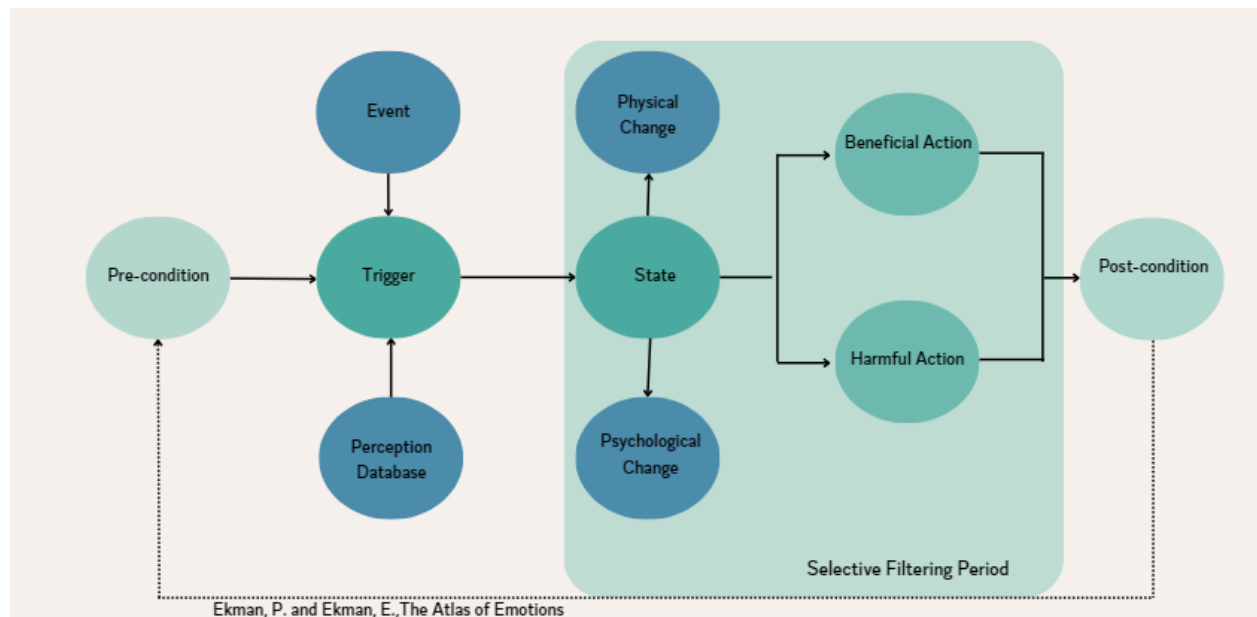
When we are emotionally aware, we can tell the difference between helpful and harmful thoughts by noticing them more clearly in the present moment. But how does this help us in our daily lives?

Imagine you have a difficult conversation with your boss/teacher that upsets you first thing in the morning. Without emotional awareness, it would be hard to recover and continue with your day. You might keep thinking about the conversation all day and struggle to focus on your work. By the end of the day, you could be angry at your boss for/teacher the conversation, angry at yourself for not finishing your work, and you might take all this anger and frustration home. When you get home, even a small question or comment from a family member could irritate you, leading you to be rude to them. This shows how one small situation at work can affect other parts of your life.

Think of this chain reaction like a small spark growing into a forest fire. It starts as a tiny, easily manageable spark, but once it becomes a large fire, it's much harder to control and can cause a big damage.

This kind of thought chain happens so quickly that we often don't realize it's happening. An angry outburst might be the result of a chain of thoughts that got out of control after a moment of frustration.. This is a natural process in your mind and body, but you can learn how to take control and stop these tiny sparks before they turn into a mental and emotional wildfire.

Spark to Forest Fire



In this section, we'll explore a helpful psychological model that explains how a small spark can turn into a wildfire of emotions. While this model isn't a perfect reflection of reality, it can help us understand our experiences better and develop greater emotional awareness.

This model is inspired by the Atlas of Emotions by Paul and Eve Ekman.

Precondition

Every experience starts with a precondition, which is the state of your body and mind before anything happens.

Imagine waking up late feeling tired and stressed because you didn't get enough sleep. This tiredness is your precondition.

Event

Next, an event happens. This could be something external, like someone saying something to you, or internal, like a thought or physical sensation.

Since you already woke up late, you are running late for college/work and you are hurrying, you spill tea all over yourself.

Perception Database

Every event is filtered through your perception database, which is influenced by your past experiences and personal history. This means that each person reacts to events in their own unique way.

Because you've had stressful mornings before, spilling tea might trigger memories of similar situations where you were rushed and upset.

Trigger (The Spark)

The combination of your precondition, the event, and your perception creates a trigger, or spark, which causes an automatic emotional response.

The tea spilling incident triggers feelings of frustration and stress, making you feel even more irritated and overwhelmed.

Emotional Response

This trigger leads to an emotional response, which can include physical reactions like sweating or trembling, and mental changes like feelings of anger or anxiety.

After spilling your tea, you might feel your heart race, and have thoughts like, "I need to change, but I'm already late!" or "why does this always happen to me" or "Why can't I ever be on time" flood your mind.

Action (Beneficial or Harmful):

Your emotional state then leads to an action, which can be either beneficial or harmful. Beneficial actions lead to well-being, while harmful actions cause more suffering.

If you let your frustration control you, you will leave home in a bad mood and might have an argument with a classmate or have problems focusing during the day. Instead, you could take some minutes to regulate your emotions and focus on leaving home for the day.

Selective Filtering (Putting Out the Spark):

Even though it might feel like we automatically jump from emotion to action, there's a moment where we can choose how to respond. This is called selective filtering, where we decide whether to act in a beneficial or harmful way.

After spilling the tea, you pause and use tools like grounding or resourcing to regulate yourself, change into a fresh pair of clothes and move on with your day instead of letting one event ruin your mood. This is where skills like emotional awareness and staying calm (equanimity) help.

Do apply this model to your daily experiences and note at what point you choose to put out the spark!